

KINJARAPU RAMMOHAN NAIDU, *36* | TDP
Minister of Civil Aviation

Engineer by training The third-term MP from Andhra Pradesh's Srikakulam holds an Electrical Engineering degree from Purdue University and an MBA from Long Island University, US

Accidental politician The youngest-ever civil aviation minister entered politics after the untimely death of his father, Kinjarapu Yerran Naidu, a prominent TDP leader, in a road accident

Minister of State

MURLIDHAR MOHOL, *49* | BJP

RSS roots The first-time MP from Pune has been an RSS worker since his young days and has served as the Mayor of Pune

Tackling Turbulence

With rising passengers, the ministry needs to enhance infrastructure, passenger services and safety, besides promoting regional connectivity

By AVISHEK G. DASTIDAR

Aviation has been the sunrise sector post the pandemic, with the number of air passengers rising every year, making it viable for Indian carriers to go into an expansion mode. Riding this boom, the government has envisioned creating multiple international hubs in India, akin to those in Dubai, Doha and Turkey. Service deficiencies by airlines and user discontent are common in the sector, which make the ministry's role as a watchdog crucial, especially with more and more airlines and flights entering Indian skies. Ensuring hassle-free and affordable air travel for the common man has been one of the Modi government's promises since 2014, a commitment that the civil aviation ministry has been tasked to oversee. ■

WHAT NEEDS TO BE DONE

AVIATION HUB The government in the previous term had set in motion the consultation process to make the Indira Gandhi International Airport in Delhi India's first international aviation hub where, operating in a hub and spoke model, flights will bring in passengers from all over the region to take off for destinations in the West. NDA 3.0 needs to fast-track the idea

REGIONAL CONNECTIVITY Expanding the regional connectivity network with more affordable routes under the UDAN scheme will help share the load with other modes like railways and highways. The Airports Authority of India plans to upgrade such airports at a cost of Rs 20,000 crore over the next five years